

WEAPONS, UNIFORM, AND KIT OF AN ORDINARY BRITISH SAILOR

The phenomenal success of British sea power in the French Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars depended not only on the tactical genius of commanders, but also on the bravery of the Royal Navy's well-drilled seamen, or "Jack Tars". Ordinary sailors' onboard duties chiefly involved the upkeep and running of the ship and the firing of its guns, although the men were issued with a pike, axe, cutlass, and pistols for boarding raids. A Jack Tar did not have a uniform, but he would have been identifiable from his outfit, which typically included a checked shirt, a short jacket, and a waistcoat.

► ROUND HAT

Date c.1800

Origin England

Material Tarred straw

Sailors sported a variety of headgear. Straw hats, popular in sunny latitudes, were often tarred to make them waterproof. The "round hat" had a tall crown like that of a top hat.

Brim, usually of narrow width



Black-painted iron grip

◀ NAVAL CUTLASS MODEL 1804

Date 1804

Origin England

Weight 1.32kg (3lb)

Length 85.5cm (33½in)

The British Model 1804 cutlass was a utilitarian, straight-bladed, cut-and-thrust weapon with a double disc guard and a ribbed iron handle, painted black to protect against corrosion.

Straight, almost flat steel blade

► WAISTCOAT

Date c.1800

Origin England

Material Wool

A colourful waistcoat was a fairly standard piece of clothing for seamen. Being skilled at repairing sails, many sailors were accomplished needleworkers, making and mending most of their own clothes.

Blade tapered to stabbing point

Spike could be driven into hull of an enemy ship to make a step or handhold

► BOARDING AXE

Date c.1800

Origin England

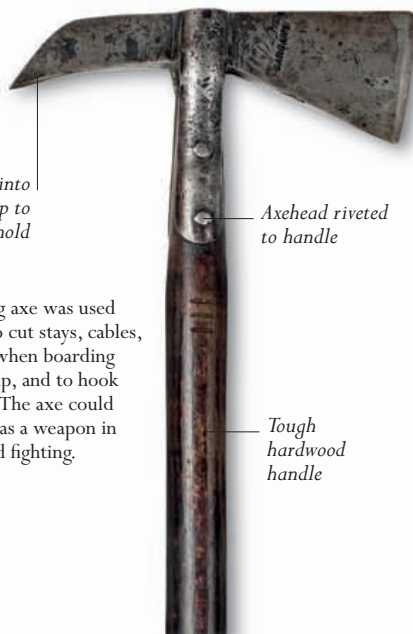
Weight 1.8kg (4lb)

Length 1m (3¼ft)

The boarding axe was used by seamen to cut stays, cables, and rigging when boarding an enemy ship, and to hook away debris. The axe could also be used as a weapon in hand-to-hand fighting.

Axehead riveted to handle

Tough hardwood handle



► TROUSERS

Date c.1800

Origin England

Material Cotton

Seamen generally wore loose trousers for ease of movement. They favoured "white duck", a hard-wearing cotton weave, and the trousers could be of any colour or pattern – many were striped.

Red woollen cloth

